The Crucifixion

By James Weldon Johnson

INTRODUCTION

According to the Gospels, Jesus had no particular quarrel with Rome and did not violate Roman law. And yet he was executed by a means exclusively reserved for those guilty of crimes against the empire. Crucifixion is a "cruel and unusual" punishment, calculated to derive the maximum amount of suffering. First a flogging and weakening by a loss of blood. Then outstretched arms fashioned by throngs or nails to a heavy wooden beam, which the victim carried across his neck and shoulders to the place of execution.
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Jesus, my gentle Jesus,

Walking in the dark of the Garden –

The Garden of Gethsemane,

Saying to the three disciples:

Sorrow is in my soul –

Even unto death;

Tarry ye here a little while,

And watch with me.

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Jesus, my burdened Jesus,

Praying in the dark of the Garden –

The Garden of Gethsemane.

Saying: Father,

Oh, Father,

This bitter cup,

This bitter cup,

Let it pass from me.

Jesus, my sorrowing Jesus,

The sweat like drops of blood upon his brow,

Talking with his Father,

While the three disciples slept,

Saying: Father,

Oh, Father,

Not as I will,

Not as I will,

But let thy will be done.

Oh, look at black-hearted Judas –

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Sneaking through the dark of the Garden –
Leading his crucifying mob.
Oh, God!
Strike him down!
Why don't you strike him down,
Before he plants his traitor's kiss
Upon my Jesus' cheek?

And they take my blameless Jesus,
And they drag him to the Governor,
To the mighty Roman Governor.
Great Pilate seated in his hall, –
Said: In this man I find no fault.
I find no fault in him.
And Pilate washed his hands.
But they cried out, saying:
Crucify him! –
Crucify him! –
Crucify him! –
His blood be on our heads.
And they beat my loving Jesus,

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They spit on my precious Jesus;
They dressed him up in a purple robe,
They put a crown of thorns upon his head,
And they pressed it down –
Oh, they pressed it down –
And they mocked my sweet King Jesus.

Up Golgotha's rugged road
I see my Jesus go.
I see him sink beneath the load,
I see my drooping Jesus sink.
And then they laid hold on Simon,
Black Simon, yes, black Simon,
And Simon bore the cross.

On Calvary, on Calvary,
They crucified my Jesus.
They nailed him to the cruel tree,
And the hammer!
The hammer!
The hammer!

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Rang through Jerusalem's streets.
The hammer!
The hammer!
The hammer!
Rang through Jerusalem's streets.

Jesus, my lamb-like Jesus,
Shivering as the nails go through his hands;
Jesus, my lamb-like Jesus,
Shivering as the nails go through his feet.
Jesus, my darling Jesus,
Groaning as the blood came spurting from his wound.
Oh, look how they done my Jesus.

Mary,
Weeping Mary,
Sees her poor little Jesus on the cross.
Mary,
Weeping Mary,
Sees her sweet, baby Jesus on the cruel cross,
Hanging between two thieves.

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And Jesus, my lonesome Jesus,
Called out once more to his Father,
Saying:
My God,
My God,
Why hast thou forsaken me?
And he drooped his head and died.

And the veil of the temple was split in two,
The midday sun refused to shine,
The thunder rumbled and the lightning wrote
And unknown language in the sky.
What a day! Lord, what a day!
When my blessed Jesus died.

Oh, I tremble, yes, I tremble,
It causes me to tremble, tremble,
When I think how Jesus died;
Died on the steeps of Calvary,
How Jesus died for sinners,
Sinners like you and me.

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